Chapter Four - The Birth of Ado

At ten years old, having awakened to the world of Utaite, I felt a growing pull day by day—a desire that whispered, "I want to be an Utaite too." My friend, who had first introduced me to them, and I would get swept up in excited conversations about our favorite singers, often talking about how we wanted to become just like them one day.

"If both you and I, Ao-chan, can become Utaite, imagine if we did game commentary together!"

"That would be the best! Starting with a collaboration and then forming a unit... that's the dream."

That friend used to secretly bring a magazine to school—a dream-like publication specialized for singers called *The Book of Utattemita*—and show it to me in the classroom after school.

"This Utaite I've been listening to lately is amazing. Do you know them, Ao-chan?"

"Oh, I know them! Their art is great too, right?"

"Right?! They're a total genius. Who have you been listening to lately, Ao-chan?"

"Um, for me... I love this person, and oh, and this person too..."

I dove headfirst into the world of Utaite existing on Niconico Dōga and Ugomemo, experiencing one wave of emotion after another.

As I listened to song after song and delved deeper into the unique worlds created by each singer, a realization struck me one day. It was vivid, as if a lightbulb had suddenly flashed bright right before my eyes.

"That's it! One day, I want to be featured in *The Book of Utattemita*, get invited to Niconico Chō Party, and become a famous Utaite who stands on a real stage!!!"

The desire to "become someone," which I thought I had discarded the day I took off my dress and put on light-blue clothes, surged back with a roar, filling my heart.

My first goal was to start activities as an Utaite within my own field: Ugomemo. I had once posted a single phrase from *Senbonzakura* sung a cappella, but since then, I had only uploaded illustrations. I decided that if I wanted to get closer to my dream, I had to take a proper first step.

The friend I had bonded with over the idea of forming a unit gradually became busier with club activities and cram school, and the time we spent together slowly dwindled. Since we were in different classes to begin with, I didn't force myself to invite her out; instead, I decided to shut myself away in my closet at home to record. I breathed life into songs, timing them to match simple animations I drew myself. This time, rather than a cappella, I included the *off-vocal* source.

By the time I had posted several videos, I had made some friends within Ugomemo. The comment sections were lined with words like "I seriously love this," "What are you singing next?" and "You're so good!" I wondered if this was the first time I had ever been praised this much by peers. Was it real? I was simply singing because I loved it, but I was beyond happy.

*Off-vocal source: An audio track containing only the accompaniment with the vocals removed. Also referred to as a karaoke track or instrumental.

At that time, an Utaite named Ruri Shion was incredibly popular on Ugomemo. Triggered by posts from Ruri Shion and her fans, I began learning new songs one after another.

Oh, I am so glad I discovered Utaite. This is where I belong. As long as I listened to Vocaloid and sang, the center of my heart remained hot with passion.

Having liberated the "love" within me through meeting these singers, I also began spending a vast amount of time on my other hobby: illustration. I posted hand-drawn animations of original characters on Ugomemo, and filled the walls of my secret base with drawings of Hatsune Miku, my favorite Utaite, and game commentators...

As I gazed upon the finished illustrations, immersed in a sense of accomplishment, I began to think that being an "Utaite who can draw" might also be wonderful. Creating and drawing characters was fun, and I felt it suited me. My creations existed only within a tiny, tiny world, but the completed drawings were treasures I wanted to hold onto and never let go.

However, the evaluation from those around me was different.

There was a girl in my class who was very skilled at drawing; she was always being praised by everyone. One day, a girl from another class asked me, "Ao-chan, would it be okay if I had you draw something for me?" and I answered immediately, "Yeah, sure!!" Just as I was thinking about what kind of picture to create, she told me:

"Actually, never mind. I found someone who's better."

As expected, that "someone who's better" was that girl in my class.

It's okay; I knew it, I told myself. It would be a lie to say I wasn't sad at all, but I could certainly understand the feelings of someone who decided they didn't "need" my illustrations. I simply

love drawing, so I should just draw for myself. With that thought, I continued to draw quietly every day.

During breaks between classes and during lunch after school meals, I sat alone, silently drawing in my notebook.

One day, some boys from my class peered over my shoulder and said mockingly:

"Ugh, gross!"

"Sawaki's always drawing weird pictures."

They were reacting to an illustration of Hatsune Miku I was working on. To them—boys who had never seen or heard of Vocaloid—it probably looked like some unfamiliar anime art.

"I draw it because I like it, so leave me alone," I replied curtly, finding them annoying. Meanwhile, a few seats away, cheers were erupting over the drawings of the skilled girl: "Whoa, amazing!" "It's like a professional manga artist!" Watching that scene blankly, I muttered words of pessimism uncharacteristic for an elementary schooler: "See? That's just how reality works."

But when I returned home, the words I thought I had brushed off began to weigh heavily on me. *Maybe I really am bad at drawing...* I truly wanted art to be my specialty. *I'm not good at anything, and I guess I'm no good at drawing either.* Once again, I spiraled into these gloomy thoughts. That night, even after getting into bed, I couldn't sleep well.

Still, the world of Vocaloid could wash away that melancholy in an instant.

What gripped my heart most of all was the *Kagerou Project*. It was a series of works that began with the song "Jinzo Enemy," posted to Niconico Dōga in 2011 by the Vocaloid-P named Jin; the story unfolded across various media, including music, novels, manga, and anime. The sheer scale of its expansion was beyond anything I could imagine as an elementary school student.

Among it all, I was absolutely floored by how cool the anime *Mekakucity Actors* was.

It is a story about middle and high school students called the "Mekakushi-dan" who possess mysterious abilities related to their "eyes," using those powers to solve mysteries and tackle incidents. Kido, Seto, Kano, Mary, Momo, Ene, Shintaro, Hibiya, Konoha, Ayano... the charm of each member cannot be exhausted in a few words. Oh, I wanted to be a member of the Mekakushi-dan; if I could use an ability, what would it be? What would be best? I fantasized about this over and over again.

Before the anime began broadcasting, 15-second commercials introducing one character per week were released. The first aired on January 25, 2014, at exactly 23:59:45, and for ten consecutive weeks after that, character visuals and cast information were gradually revealed.

Despite it being the middle of the night, I sat in seiza before the living room television, waiting for that moment.

Fifteen minutes left. Ten minutes left. It's still not here. It's only fifteen seconds long; I absolutely cannot miss it. Three minutes left.

And finally...

"It's here—!"

First, the sheer emotion of hearing my favorite characters speak took my breath away.

But that wasn't all that struck me. A story I had only ever seen within Niconico Dōga was now flowing across a television screen. Though I thought I understood it intellectually, seeing it right in front of me left me stunned. *This is actually happening...* My fingertips trembled at the realization that I was witnessing a moment where history was changing.

After repeating that feeling ten times over, I finally reached the premiere of the anime on April 12th, at midnight. With an expression far more serious than any face I ever showed at school, I followed every movement of the Mekakushi-dan on screen without even blinking.

It was so wonderful. The fact that my favorite characters were moving, that Vocaloid songs were echoing from the TV, and that Vocaloid culture was spreading—it all made me too happy for words. For an elementary school student, it was a very late hour to be awake, but every time I saw the Mekakushi-dan in action, I felt a powerful surge of conviction: *I want to live for tomorrow.*

As I entered the sixth grade, my "Vocaloid index" continued to rise, and while my heart felt vibrant, my position within the class remained that of the "shy girl who likes drawing."

However, there were some happy moments. I was chosen as an illustration assistant. It was a role where I drew illustrations for handouts distributed in class or for the wall newspaper; three other girls in the class who were also said to be good at art were selected alongside me. One day, just before summer vacation, I received an illustration request from a boy I had never even spoken to.

"Sawaki, you're one of the illustration assistants, right? Could you draw something for me? Anything is fine."

"...Uh, sure. Anything really?"

"Yeah, it's up to you!"

The boy handed me a small piece of paper torn from a sketchbook. Thinking he might just like art and wanted something to keep in his textbook or notebook, I didn't overthink it and simply drew a girl wearing a school uniform.

I had been asked by girls occasionally, but being asked by a boy was so rare that my heart leaped with excitement. During lunch break, I finished the drawing and handed it to him; he said "Thank you!" with a smile and ran off with the illustration. The idea that my art could be something someone actually wanted—I was so happy I couldn't help but grin.

However, an incident occurred during cleaning time that day. If I had to name it, I'd call it the "Trash Can Illustration Incident."

The details are exactly as the name suggests. The drawing I had given to that boy was crumpled into a ball and thrown into the class trash can. Furthermore, another illustration assistant—a girl who had been asked for a drawing by a different boy—had her art found in the same state, crumpled up in the trash.

The classroom became chaotic. That other girl burst into tears. She picked up her torn drawing from the trash and appealed to the teacher, tears streaming down her face without any attempt to wipe them away: "This is too cruel! I worked so hard on it because he asked me to! This is unbelievable!"

I could see that. But I remain still. I didn't pick up my own drawing from the trash, nor did I shed a single tear. I wasn't even angry. Rather, my heart felt as cold as ice, and my mind became increasingly calm.

I see. It was thrown away because it's bad. If it were a great piece of art, they wouldn't have thrown it away. That must be it. After all, there is no one who actually wants my drawings. I am not suited for drawing. Becoming a manga artist or an illustrator is impossible.

Human behavior can be cruel, and it wounds the heart deeper than one would imagine. Watching the girl next to me cry, I vaguely thought that I should live by covering my heart with a hard shell, like an armadillo.

I couldn't do anything well—not studying, not sports, not making friends—and now, even the art I had spent so long drawing was useless. Thinking these things, summer vacation arrived, and eventually, the ginkgo leaves turned completely gold, and the season shifted to autumn.

When I got home and crawled into my closet as usual to play games on my DS, I suddenly felt like I heard someone else's voice—a voice that wasn't mine—and stopped playing.

That's right. I wanted to be an Utaite!!!

I never thought I was good at singing. I had never been praised in music class. But since discovering Vocaloids and Utaites, the act of singing simply because I loved it, and the joy of having someone listen to my voice, became a source of happiness. Opening "UgoMemo" (animated memos), which I hadn't posted to for a while because I was so absorbed in drawing, I made a decision.

I'll become good enough that I can say to the boy who threw my art in the trash: "Thank you for breaking my spirit back then; thanks to you, I became an Utaite." There is no more time to mope around.

Pressing my face into the cushions inside the closet, I screamed.

"I want to be an Utaite! I'll definitely make it happen!!"

From that day on, I began seriously researching how to post "Utattemita" videos on Niconico Dōga.

According to the internet, various pieces of equipment were needed. Further searching revealed "Utaite Starter Sets" being sold, which contained everything necessary for recording and posting.

For Christmas in the sixth grade, I wrote a letter to Santa.

Dear Santa, Ao wants an Utaite Starter Set. Please.

And when Christmas Day arrived, a formidable, magnificent box was placed under the tree in the living room.

An Utaite Starter Set!!!

My father and my mother were smiling, saying things like "That's great," "Singing is wonderful," and "Ao-chan is really good at singing."

Thank you, Santa!!!!!

So, what do I do next?

I researched the internet again. Once I had the Utaite Starter Set in hand, the first step was setting it up. I needed a computer to connect the equipment, so I borrowed my father's PC.

Headphones
Audio Interface

DAW Software
Condenser Microphone
Microphone Stand
Pop Filter

Amazing. If I connected this whole set to the computer, I too could become an Utaite.

The moment I thought that, the voices of the Utaites I had listened to until now echoed in my head, and my fantasies expanded. The day after my first post, 100,000 views; the "Promising Newcomer" tag would cause a stir in the comments section. Eventually, it would become a rumor at school, and people would be questioned: "The identity of that Utaite... could it possibly be Ao-chan!???"

However, the excitement didn't last long. As I stared intently at the instruction manual for the Utaite Starter Set I had brought into my closet, my face gradually turned pale.

Can I really do this?

From that day on, began my days of challenging myself to set up the equipment. I read the manual, watched tutorial videos for the starter set, fiddled with it a bit, found that something wasn't working, and went back to the manual and videos.

The manual, filled with rows of tiny text, stated that first one must install the DAW on the computer, connect the computer and audio interface via USB, and then connect the microphone and headphones to the interface.

The first thing I tripped over was "DAW." Searching for it, I found it was music production software capable of recording, editing, and mixing. The procedure for using it was: "Install the interface driver, select that interface as the input/output in the DAW settings, and adjust the microphone's input gain and headphone volume"...

Wait, what? What am I supposed to do!?!?

Let's start with the microphone. It's quite different from a karaoke machine. But what exactly is the difference?

Um, then next is "interface driver"... D-driver? What's a driver?

"After recording with the DAW, export." Export? Suddenly I have to write something?

And after recording, "align the start position (timing) of playback by performing head-alignment"? Align... the head...?

It's no use; I don't understand any of it. The tasks are explained using words I don't know.

I decided to research the meaning of every single term first, searching and immersing myself in websites one after another. Even though I wanted to sing and post right now—to get closer to the Utaites I admired—I couldn't even manage to record a single thing.

In times like this, normally people would ask their parents. But I didn't do that. Because I was a child, since I had obtained the equipment...

I had no choice but to rely on my parents for the initial purchase of equipment. However, from the very beginning, I had no intention of asking for help with the subsequent setup. For some reason, I felt that the path toward becoming an Utaite was the one thing I had to carve out with my own two hands. I wanted to reach that world entirely on my own.

Bit by bit, I learned the roles and functions of each piece of gear; I would touch a knob, stop, and then timidly try recording just a single phrase. To an outsider, my progress might have looked like the crawl of a tortoise, but in my mind, I was already an "Utaite-in-training."

Around this time, I found myself gradually drifting away from my DS, which had once felt like a part of my own body. I wasn't a child anymore; the next stage was waiting for me. Those feelings shuffled through my mind, and the hours I used to spend on my DS were steadily replaced by time spent tracking Vocaloid information online and grappling with my Utaite starter set.

With the ultimate goal of posting to Niconico Dōga, I also began reviewing the implicit rules and etiquette of the platform.

At the center of the Vocaloid world are the great "Honke-sama." This term refers to both the original creator who wrote the song and the original music video—essentially, the primary source material. An "Utattemita" (I tried singing) video is a piece of derivative work that layers one's own expression over that source. The absolute prerequisite for this is showing respect to the Honke-sama through proper credits, links, and adherence to guidelines.

In this world, there is a deeply rooted culture where many people layer their own vocals or illustrations over the works of the Honke-sama to present them as new expressions. That is precisely why one must never lose respect for the original creator and the original work.

Alright, I've finished reviewing the basic rules. While my longing grew for the "Honke-sama" who released one god-tier song after another on Niconico Dōga, I devoted myself to deciphering manuals and setting up my equipment, dreaming of the day I could layer my own "Utattemita" over their music. It wasn't an exaggeration to say that for twenty-four hours a day, the words "I tried singing" were practically plastered inside my forehead.

The battle with the equipment lasted longer than I had imagined. But even during that time, I wanted to sing. I wanted to post. So, as a prelude to Niconico Dōga, I started making "pseudo-Utattemita" videos on an app called "nana," where one could easily upload short clips of about a minute and a half. Since nana allowed you to record and post instantly, the operation was simple. I sang a wide variety of songs, primarily Vocaloid ones, and before I knew it, I had uploaded about thirty tracks.

As I continued posting, people appeared who could actually be called "fans."

"First time listening. I love your singing style!"
"Following you! m(__)m"
"This is incredibly cool, the best!"

Receiving these comments made me so happy that I sang even more. Eventually, the number of such people grew, and they began to listen to my songs every time I posted.

If it felt this wonderful on nana, I wondered what kind of joy would be waiting for me once I made my Niconico Dōga debut... Using the warm comments from nana as fuel for my equipment setup, I kept imagining that debut day which would surely come one day.

Around the time I entered junior high school, the Sawaki family moved again. The nearest station remained the same, but this time we were on the eighth floor of an apartment near the station. It even had a long-awaited elevator. Oh, how grateful I was for the power of civilization. But that wasn't all—I finally had my own room. It was a corner room with a window where I could overlook the city lights at night. With my own room, I could sing as much as I wanted, whenever I wanted. I no longer had to worry about my parents' gaze.

When I told them I wanted to pursue activities as an Utaite, neither my father nor my mother opposed me. They might not have understood the exact difference between a professional singer and an Utaite, but they supported my singing.

"If that's what you want to do, then go ahead. It's fine to do what you love and enjoy yourself," my mother said. "But Ao-chan, when you get too enthusiastic, you tend to lose sight of your surroundings, so please be very careful with the volume. If you bother the neighbors, you won't be able to keep doing it."

"Ao is truly skilled at singing," my father added. "It's the result of the gifted education I provided."

I can keep singing from now on. Thinking that brought me a sense of relief. Yet, contrary to that peace, dark clouds began to gather in my heart. Recently, I had started feeling a sense of dissonance toward the words my parents spoke when thinking of their daughter. Even though I was listening carefully, the words simply passed through my head—like eyes following subtitles on a silent drama.

Suddenly, everything became depressing, and I dove onto the bed in my room. Every family has its own circumstances. It's not just me. Even as I told myself this, those circumstances felt too heavy for a junior high school student to bear, and I whispered to myself in a small voice:

"I want to grow up quickly, Ao."

In my junior high class, there were four other kids who loved Vocaloid as much as I did. I thought it would be a miracle just to meet one person in the same grade, let alone have four of them in the same class. Along with the surprise, an indescribable joy welled up inside me.

I shared interests in manga, anime, and games with them, and we hit it off immediately. If I mentioned a Vocaloid song title, they understood right away; if I explained why I liked a certain track, they would respond with "I get that." Compared to my elementary school days when I struggled to make friends, the classroom where those four were present felt like a patch of warm sunlight to me.

Most of the kids in class liked idols like AKB48 or male vocal groups. However, such entertainment hardly moved my heart. Even when listening to J-POP hits playing over the school intercom during lunch, I only thought, "I guess this kind of thing is popular lately."

For me, the most captivating things were still Vocaloid songs. Miku's voice was strangely comfortable and fit perfectly into my ears. I was particularly obsessed with rock-style Vocaloid tracks. The sense of speed in the guitars and drums, and the way organic sounds blended with electronic ones, was exactly my taste.

I felt a certain pride in knowing a cool world that most of my classmates didn't know about, but every time the mean boys in class called me a "Vocaloid otaku" as an insult, I was driven by the urge to say, "You just don't know this world; don't make fun of it without even knowing what it is!" In an attempt to convey the splendor of Vocaloid to more people, I once asked the student in charge of music to play Vocaloid songs over the school intercom during lunch.

"Vocaloids are just robots, right? What's so great about them when there's no emotion?"

One day during lunch break, a boy from my class approached me with a smirk. As I stood there stunned, he laughed along with his followers behind him, saying, "Right? You just don't get it, do you?" Even for someone as shy as me, I couldn't stay silent after being told something like that.

"It might sound like machine noise to you, but to me, it's wonderful!"

"Ugh, gross. She's getting all heated."

"You've probably never even listened to Vocaloid properly, have you? You just don't realize it, but some of the songs by Vocaloid-Ps are ones that everyone knows. There are incredibly popular songs out there!"

"Ah, talking to an otaku is pointless."

I didn't flinch even as the boy spat out those parting words and turned on his heel. Vocaloid is so cool... I couldn't forgive him for insulting it without even trying to understand it! I wanted to do something to clear the frustration swirling in my chest.

I felt as if I were wearing a sweatshirt with "Vocaloid Love" emblazoned across the chest, burning with a sense of mission to convey the appeal of Vocaloids.

And then, that opportunity arrived in the winter of my second year of junior high. We were taking a bus to a ski trip, and it was decided that we could play favorite CDs brought by the students on the bus. Thinking "Now's my chance!", I brought along several albums from my favorite Utaite.

Among the CDs I brought was one containing a song used in a television commercial. If it were that impressive chorus, even kids who didn't know Vocaloid should have heard it at least once. With that faint hope, I boarded the bus, clutching the bag with the CD cases tightly to my chest.

When it finally became my turn for my CD to play, as soon as the intro started, a few voices asked, "What is this?"

"Ao, did you bring this CD?"

A few people in nearby seats glanced back at me. Then, the moment the song reached the chorus from that commercial, the atmosphere inside the bus changed instantly.

"Oh, I think I know this one!"

See! See! You do know it! Everyone listens to Vocaloid songs without even realizing it! Just as I secretly pumped my fist in victory, a bright girl who seemed to be at the center of the class turned around and looked at me. Wh-what is it? I've hardly ever spoken to this girl...

"Um..."

"Y-yeah?"

"Did you bring the CD of the song that's playing now, Ao-chan? It's a great track. I didn't know it, but I'm glad I got to hear it."

"Oh, then I'm glad. Thank you too..."

My mission to spread the gospel of Vocaloid had only just begun, but it had successfully reached those who were open to it. This incident on the ski trip bus gave me a small spark of

confidence. I wanted more people to understand how wonderful Vocaloids are. I felt that this was a wish I could continue to hold onto.

Then, after about two years, the setup for the "Utaite starter set" I had acquired for my twelfth birthday Christmas finally neared completion.

I'm already in my second year of middle school now. I really worked hard—truly. My heart swelled as I looked back on my elementary school self, who had been utterly lost while reading the instruction manuals. I borrowed the computer from my parents, but once I placed it in the center of the table in my room, surrounded by a microphone and audio equipment, it suddenly started to look "the part."

I mainly recorded during the weekends. Using operations I had only just learned, I sang one Vocaloid song after another into the microphone. Before I knew it, my computer was filled with folders for each song, containing audio files of only the main vocals, harmony and chorus tracks, and off-vocal sources I had downloaded.

However, there was one final hurdle before I could dive headfirst into the world of Vocaloid. Just because I recorded the songs didn't mean I could post them immediately. Next, I needed "mixing work"—the process of combining the karaoke track with the vocals and adjusting the volume and effects to finish it as a single piece of music.

Whether to do it myself or ask someone else was the question. If I were to mix it myself, I would need additional software; when I checked the prices, they ranged from 20,000 to 50,000 yen—the cheapest being 20,000 and the most expensive 50,000. That was impossible. Furthermore, a middle school student couldn't get a part-time job. My own allowance certainly wasn't enough, but I didn't want to keep begging my parents for more money.

I spent hours searching on my computer for "Vocaloid Utattemita mix." Through these searches, I discovered the existence of people called "MIX-shi" (mixing engineers). Many MIX-shi seemed to take on jobs for around 5,000 to 10,000 yen per song. Even so, that was too expensive for a middle school student like me. Using Twitter to search for "cheap mix," I eventually found out that there were some MIX-shi who would do it for free.

I can't do anything on my own, and there is so much left to do. There are still many people I need to meet, and the road ahead is endless. But right now, everything felt like a long wait.

After nearly two years of steadily preparing to post on Niconico Dōga, I finally decided on the song for my first upload.

It was "Kimi no Taion" (Your Body Temperature) by Kuwagata-P. I had discovered the song through the 3DS rhythm game series *Hatsune Miku Project Mirai*, and when I first heard it, its sheer coolness sent a strong wind blowing through my mind.

Once I decided, there was no time for hesitation. In mid-December 2016, I wrote a simple request via Twitter DM to a MIX-shi who had stated they would work for free.

"Nice to meet you. I'm aiming for my first post. Could you please mix the audio sources?"

The reply came back in a single line:

"Sure, I'll do it."

I compressed the recording data and uploaded it via an uploader site, sending the URL to this MIX-shi whose real name, age, and gender were all unknown to me.

For three weeks, my heart raced. On January 9, 2017—the last day of winter break—a notification lit up in my DMs.

"It's done. Please give it a listen."

My heart leaped.

"Thank you so much!!!"

I replied quickly and immediately downloaded the data, put on the headphones from my starter set, and pressed the play button.

Wow, amazing! My voice had become "the sound of an Utattemita video!"

The melody drowned out my wordless cry of surprise.

Captured by that vividly glowing color,
I stopped in my tracks,
Lost and simply heartbroken,
What I chased was a phantom.
I heard your nostalgic voice,
A sound that now echoes from far, far away.
Hands held tight because I wanted warmth—
We called that love.

It was a strange sensation; I was so happy that I played it over and over again.

The final step was encoding the audio source. If I didn't clear this hurdle, I couldn't post it. Perhaps my tension was transmitted via telepathy, because the MIX-shi offered: "If you like, I can handle the encoding as well."

Thanks to that kind MIX-shi, "Kimi no Taion" was successfully completed and now only awaited its upload. In truth, I wanted to post it right this second! My long-awaited life as an Utaite was finally within reach!

But then, I told myself to be calm: *Wait, wait.* I thought it would be better to announce it on Twitter and tell my friends in advance. Considering the view counts on Niconico Dōga, evening hours were easier for people to watch, so I decided on 8:00 PM. All right, decided. My Utaite debut would be tomorrow, January 10th, at 8:00 PM. I closed my eyes in front of the computer and repeated that time over and over in my head.

Encoding: The process of compressing or converting audio data into a specific format.

The next day, though I felt bad for my teacher, I couldn't concentrate on school lessons any more than usual.

When I told four of my close friends, "I'm posting my first song today," they all chimed in: "Congratulations!" "It's finally finished!" "I'll definitely leave a comment!"

I remembered that the online friends who had listened to me sing on nana the night before had given me similar words. Their kindness felt ticklish and made me feel a bit shy.

After returning home, I finally began the process of uploading the video. The moment I typed【First Post】into the brackets at the beginning of the title, my chest tightened with emotion. This was the first and last "first post" of my life.

During dinner that night, I kept glancing at the clock to make sure I didn't miss the posting time. General members of Niconico Dōga cannot use scheduled posts; in other words, I had to press the upload button manually. If I dithered and missed the timing, it might have been posted at 8:01 or 8:02 PM.

I hurried back to my room from a dinner I barely remember tasting, opened the site, and took a deep breath. Just a little longer until 8:00 PM. Will anyone watch it? I felt like I could throw up from nervousness. I wondered if the Utaite artists I always watched had felt this way before their first post.

The moment I the computer clock switched to "20:00," I held my breath and clicked the upload button. While watching the loading screen, I had only one prayer: *Please, let it go live exactly at 8:00 PM!*

When I refreshed the site...

20:00【First Post】Kimi no Taion (I tried singing)【Adovance】

I did it. A small voice escaped my lips.

Today, I finally became an Utaite. From my dim and quiet room, I had just leaped out into the world that stretched beyond the dazzling screen.

The view count slowly increased: 10, 15... Comments from accounts that looked like my friends began to scroll by. The views continued to climb: 20, 30... It had already exceeded the number of friends I had told. This meant there were people who were hearing my voice for the first time through this video.

It starts here. I had finally become a new version of myself.

I had set my Niconico Dōga account name as "Ado." The origin of the name came from a Kyogen play called *Kaki Yamabushi* that I learned about in sixth-grade Japanese class. In the story, a mountain ascetic (Yamabushi) hiding in the shade of a tree is teased by the owner of the Persian persimmon tree—first being called a "crow" and then a "monkey." Finally, he is provoked into jumping and falls. That's the story. During that lesson, I learned that in Kyogen, the main character is called the *shite* and the supporting or side role is called the *ado*.

I remember feeling that the two-syllable sound of "Ado" had a certain cleanliness and sharpness to it, which strangely stuck in my head. During my UgoMemo era, I didn't care much about names, using account names like "Letore" or "Imokenpi" based on whatever mood I was in.

I had been changing it. But when I entered junior high and felt that none of the names quite fit, I suddenly remembered a lesson from sixth grade.

"Ado" might be good. I'll go with Ado from now on. With that decided, I changed my account name on nana to the katakana version and added a comment:
I'll be going by the name Ado from now on; I've also changed the character design of my icon.

The reason I chose Ado wasn't just because it sounded cool. The meaning—"supporting role"—was important to me.
As a young child, I had eyes only for princesses, but by the time I reached elementary school, I could no longer believe that "the lead is everything." No matter how you looked at it, I was a supporting character in my class, and in manga and anime, I found myself drawn to those unconventional side characters.

The supporting role that sparkles right next to the lead basking in the spotlight. When it came time to decide roles for the elementary school play, I would often volunteer for the villain. People say "everyone is the protagonist of their own life," but only a limited number of people actually live lives where they feel like the "lead." I was, of course, a supporting character, and surely everyone else was living as a side character in someone else's life too. When I realized this, the feeling that "there is pride in being a supporting role" began to exist in my heart with a clear, defined shape.

As an Utaite, it would be wonderful if I could become a supporting character who brings a small light into someone's life.
The name "Ado," chosen with those thoughts in mind, was a name imbued with my own identity. Then, upon my debut on Niconico Dōga, I shifted to the alphabet spelling: "Ado." It was a small change, but it was an expression of my modest resolve as I took my first steps as an Utaite.

Five days after that first "Utattemita" upload—which had been achieved amidst such emotion—on January 15, 2017, I attended the first day of Mafumafu's first solo tour, *I Want to Have a LIVE Even if I'm a Shut-in!*, held at Zepp DiverCity. I had a ticket that one of my four friends had managed to get for me.

Even after the concert began, a white curtain covered the stage. When it suddenly dropped during the second song and Mafumafu appeared, the cheers from the audience grew exceptionally loud.
The person I had long admired was now standing right before my eyes. I couldn't believe this reality; I instinctively caught my breath. Up-tempo songs followed one after another, with high notes piercing through like arrows. Having known almost nothing about live concerts, I was overwhelmed by the heat of the venue, yet I found myself naturally captivated by Mafumafu's beautiful singing voice.

He looked like a star gathering all the light on stage. A presence like the North Star, shining even in the darkness to show the way forward. *I will walk the path that light guides with my own two feet.* For the first time, I felt I could see clearly where I wanted to go as an Utaite.

The concert, which started at 6:00 PM, ended and I left the venue. Riding the wave of people toward Yurikamome's Daiba Station, the night view of the bay spread out before me. The wires supporting the Rainbow Bridge drew gentle arcs in the air like ribbons dancing in the sky. Beyond that was the orange glow of Tokyo Tower and a kaleidoscope of city lights.

I stopped, feeling an indescribable, powerful emotion, and gazed at those lights for a while. The winter night wind brushed against my flushed cheeks.

While continuing to record for my second upload, I further studied how to conduct myself as an Utaite.
First, I decided not to keep asking the MIX engineer who had mixed "Kimi no Taion" for free. I felt it would be too brazen to repeatedly ask the same person for free work.

The catalyst was a warning post I saw on Twitter. It listed a lack of etiquette and awareness of rules as common troubles that occur between MIX engineers and Utaite.
"Some people are quite rude."
"Please use polite language (keigo)."
Such phrases lined the post. Although I already used keigo, I made an effort to be even more polite than before. When I looked back at the keigo I had been using, worried if it was actually

correct, I found places where I had confused honorifics with humble forms, and a cold sweat broke out. I summarized the online warnings in my own words, wrote them in a notebook, and muttered to myself:

"I have to check more carefully than before whether they take paid requests or also accept free ones."
"I should properly discuss how the credits are listed in the video description."
"Vocal sources shouldn't be stereo but *monaural... yeah, I knew that!"

Even though I was as bad at schoolwork as ever, I wanted to learn everything there was to know about Vocaloid. Perhaps because of that effort, I was able to maintain a peaceful correspondence with the MIX engineer who had helped me for free.

Just like my first upload, I searched Twitter for a MIX engineer who advertised "I will mix for free" and sent a request via DM. The reply came quickly—once again, a simple "I'll do it." The audio file that arrived afterward was once more more three-dimensional than I had imagined, with even the breathing perfectly polished.

My second upload was on April 12, 2017, in the spring of my third year of junior high. Because I wanted to record a good song—even if only slightly better—I re-recorded it so many times that I ended up releasing a winter song in the spring. Before I knew it, three months had passed since my first upload.
I typed in the title and description for Niconico Dōga:

[Even though it's Spring] I tried singing Star Night Snow [Adovantage]
Finally uploading!!!!!!
Sorry, it's been 3 months since I should have uploaded this, congratulations!!!!! And it's already spring!!!!!!! It's out of season!!!!! (????)

*Monaural: A system where the same sound comes from both left and right speakers. Used when one wants a single sound source, such as a singing voice, to be heard clearly.

I uploaded my third song, "Strangers," on June 2, 2017. At that point, I had a thought. I felt hesitant to keep asking for free help, and detailed procedures were available online. *Why not try it myself once?* It might be reckless, but it was a challenge.

Thus, I mixed the following three works myself:
Kirai Kirai Jigahidai! (August 15, 2017)
Deep Sleep (December 27, 2017)
My R (February 2, 2018)

The mixing process was more difficult than I had imagined, and there were moments when my spirit almost broke. However, by doing the mix myself, for the first time, the flow from a raw

voice to an "Utattemita" sound connected as a single line. I was deeply happy to have gained that sensation.

Around this time, there was also a change in my recording environment. The catalyst was the Utaite Wolpis Carter.
Wolpis is an Utaite known for his high-tone voice and holds the nickname "The Boy Who Wants to Hit High Notes."

One day, bored with equipment settings that weren't progressing well, I flopped down on the floor. In my line of sight was a copy of *Utattemita Book March 2015* on my bookshelf. Thinking I might read it again for the first time since sixth grade, I picked it up casually and found an interview with Wolpis. I realized I hadn't read this article properly before. It said, "To increase concentration during recording, I cover myself with a duvet," accompanied by a photo of him home-recording in a corner of his house. The moment I saw that, inspiration struck me.

I see, I can just be creative and make a recording booth at home. Then I'll try recording in my room's closet!
It was the return of the secret base I used to hide in back when I didn't have my own room. Of course, since it was a closet, there was only enough space for a tiny bit of room on either side of me when sitting, but as someone raised in closets, it felt incredibly comfortable.

I brought in a small table and placed my computer on top of it. Singing alone in that cramped space just felt right. *Maybe I should stick sound-absorbing materials to the walls too? I'll save up my allowance and try buying some next time.*
Whenever I listened to Wolpis's songs shortly after creating my closet studio, I would press my hands together in a silent "thank you" for the inspiration.

My debut on Niconico Dōga had been a major event for me. But as an Utaite, Ado—and those "Utattemita" videos...

Things weren't expanding at all. I wished that one day it would reach 10,000 views, but in reality, Ado was just a tiny, grain-of-sand sized Utaite within the world of Niconico Dōga.

One such day, a single DM arrived on Twitter.
"If you're okay with it, would you let me do your mixing?"

It had been about a year since my debut on Niconico. I was in the third year of middle school, and I was being asked—not as the one making the request, but from their side.

"Thank you so much. Yes, please!"
Surprise and joy raced through my chest. The other person sent me several of their own sound sources, so I understood their skill level immediately. They were a mixing engineer and sound director; a popular MIX-shi* who handled the mixing for many Utaite. Through our DM exchanges, I learned they were seven years older than me.

Every now and then, he would say:
"Let's work hard together to increase your view counts."

That was right. He was absolutely correct. To survive as an Utaite, I couldn't remain in an amateur mindset. It was at this moment that the ambition to drive up the numbers began to sprout within me.

MIX-shi even gave me advice on how to post my videos. Whenever I said, "I think I'll try singing this song next," or "I want to sing this song in this way," he would respond with precise guidance: "If you do that, it will overlap too much with your previous song. Let's try targeting a different style next time," or "Post it at X o'clock. That's when impressions grow the most."

I had been bothered by the poor quality of my own mixing on *Kirai Kirai Jigahidai!* by Takeaki Wada (Kurage-P), so I re-recorded it and handed the data over to the MIX-shi. He got to work immediately. It seemed he arranged for an acquaintance to handle the encoding, and the process moved toward uploading in the blink of an eye.

***Kirai Kirai Jigahidai!* Utattemita [Adoption]**
(Encoding was impossible)
I re-recorded this one.

[Good evening, I'm Ado. My recent struggle is that my computer is way too slow. I want a new one.
By the way, because of the computer, even though I planned to post this at 8:00 PM, it ended up being posted after 8:00 PM.
I think I'll smash my computer later.

E-X***
ENC.***]

The biggest change in the re-recorded *Kirai Kirai Jigahidai!* was my singing style. Until then, I had been using a soft tone centered on falsetto, deciding for myself that "Ado is this kind of singer." However, when it came time to record this song a second time, I fundamentally reconsidered how I actually wanted to sing.

The character singing the original song is eleven years old and has a cute voice with a lingering childishness. Perhaps because of that, many Utaite who cover it are "cute-type" singers. I certainly thought that the gap created by singing intense emotions with a cute voice was great, but I wondered if there might be another way to express it.

Wouldn't it be okay to just go all out and "growl" using my chest voice?

One of my favorite Utaite is someone named Megatera Zero. Among male Utaite, he uses a lot of growling components, and his rock-style singing is incredibly cool. I tried incorporating those techniques in my own way and faced the song *Kirai Kirai Jigahidai!* once more.

"Ah! I want to be loved! I want to be loved!"
"More than that girl over there,"
"I've grown this much now!"
"Look, just look at it! Ah!"
"I want to be praised! I want to be praised!"
"I know how to do it,"
"Just like that girl did to me,"
"I should just crush the trash under my feet, right?"

The reaction to the video was better than usual. The comment section was lively, and I felt as though the view count was growing faster. Perhaps this singing style suited me better. *Alright, let's find a "growl" that is uniquely mine.*

Thus began my "growl research." And the more I sang, the more questions swirled within me. *What is a way of singing that is like me—that is like Ado? What kind of expression fits this song best?*

I would sometimes smooth out a rough growl; other times, I would make sure the lyrics were delivered with sharp clarity. I pushed my own arrangements to their limit or intentionally leaned toward something standard. For every song, I searched for the expression and explored what "cool" meant to me.

As I listened to the original songs and sang them over and over while thinking about how I wanted to express them, intuition began to take hold. *Here it should be gentle; here I should growl; here falsetto; here chest voice.* In that way, little by little, "Ado's style" was formed.

In the moments of growling, emotions spark like fire within my body. It isn't just about being angry or shouting. Yet, like a pendulum, my heart swings violently. Perhaps it is through that swing that I can move the emotions of the listener. Whether stretching a high, thin voice like a thread of honey, or shattering the silence with a voice that sounds as if it were breaking apart—as long as there was a melody and lyrics, they began to flow immediately from my throat.

At the same time, this was the moment I discovered the singer known as "Ado."